Anytime, anywhere communication has changed our lives drastically and permanently. Ever since the debut of the first brick-sized cellular phone, there's been a breathtaking spiral in cellular technology.

Cellular phones have become increasingly compact and have simultaneously managed to incorporate an array of features and capabilities, ranging from Internet access to the ability to transfer video and even maintain your entire year's schedule!

Back in the 1990s, handsets were big, ungainly devices and were primarily used just for what they were made for—voice communication. Period. Over the last decade, this technology has metamorphosed to usher in a web of applications and services that have spawned a whole new range of functionality. Cell phones now have the ability to store extensive contact details and reminders, exchange voice and text messages and even tune in to your favourite FM station or play your favourite digital music. At the higher end of the spectrum, there are devices that far exceed the specifications of simple cell phones to attain the status of full-blown communication and computing devices.

One factor that has driven the design and the implementation of cellular devices is the fact that they are now no longer just utilitarian devices—they have become an integral part of a person's lifestyle, reflecting the user's character and status. This is probably the largest driver of cell phone design where styling, form factor, colours, personalisation and just pure funk value have taken priority in the process of buying a cell phone. Interchangeable faceplates, fluorescent multicoloured screens and keypad lights, polyphonic ring tones that could give a dozen canaries a run for their money—you name it and the feature is there on today's cellular devices.

As cellular phones have expanded in terms of functionality to incorporate all these cool features, their basic job as a communication device has also seen tremendous advancements in terms of sheer technology. While GSM is still the most widely used standard, there are many consortiums that are working towards taking mobile communication to the next level. Think permanent Internet connectivity, full-motion video, CD-quality audio and crystal clear voice reception—all this is now becoming a reality with the development and acceptance of new communications standards like GPRS and 3G. Like all new technologies, there is a gestation period where they mature and where costs of implementation get lowered so that they eventually become accessible to the common user. These bleeding-edge standards have made inroads only in very select regions in the world where they are being tested for feasibility, reliability and cost of implementation. However, we are not really too far away from the day when your cellular phone will

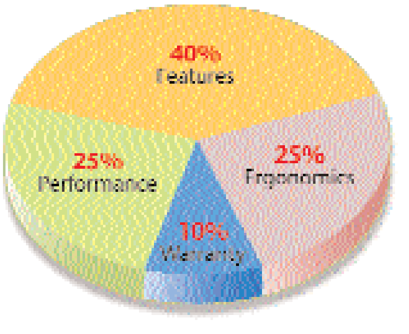
Digit Test Process

Qualification criteria

In this, the first and the largest cellular phone test in the country, we tested 22 phones over a range of categories. We only evaluated phones that support the GSM and/or the GPRS standard. We categorised the phones into three price ranges: phones up to Rs 10,000, phones between Rs 10,001 and Rs 18,000 and phones priced greater than Rs 18,000. These are the end-user prices as provided by the companies. These price categorisations were decided on the basis of the various features of the phone and the target audience. We tested only box-packed units that come with all the pertinent accessories—no grey market phones were taken into consideration.

Test Methodology

The cell phones were evaluated on various parameters using a series of tests. The overall score was arrived at by putting together the scores in each of these areas.



Features: Here we awarded points depending on the features and capabilities of the phone. These included the type of battery used, the presence of PIM features such as reminders and To-do lists, the availability of predictive text input, ring tones support, screensavers, operator logos, games, support for newer standards like GPRS, the type of the display used, etc. We also checked the number of accessories that were bundled with the phone and for special features such as MP3 functionality, an integrated PDA, etc.

Ergonomics: We evaluated the weight and size of the phones along with the build quality, the overall design, shape and layout of the phone, and its ease of navigation.

Performance: The phones were tested for voice quality, charging time, standby time and talk time, and storage capacity. The talk time scores are only indicative—they could vary depending upon the area of usage, signal strength, the service provider used, time of day, etc. In order to maintain the constancy of the network, we used a single service provider while testing the cellular phones. The voice quality tests were performed by dialling an automated voice response number of the service provider from a fixed location from where signal strength was high. Here, we graded the phones for volume, clarity and timbre of the voice. For the signal strength tests, we took the phones to four specific locations with varying signal strengths and in each of these areas, we logged the ability of the phone to receive the signal and reliably make and receive calls. These zones included areas like stairwells, basements, open outdoor areas, etc.

Warranty: We took into account the warranty period, the number of authorised service centres appointed by the company, the number of cities in which authorised service centres are present and whether users are provided a standby cell phone while the original one was being repaired.